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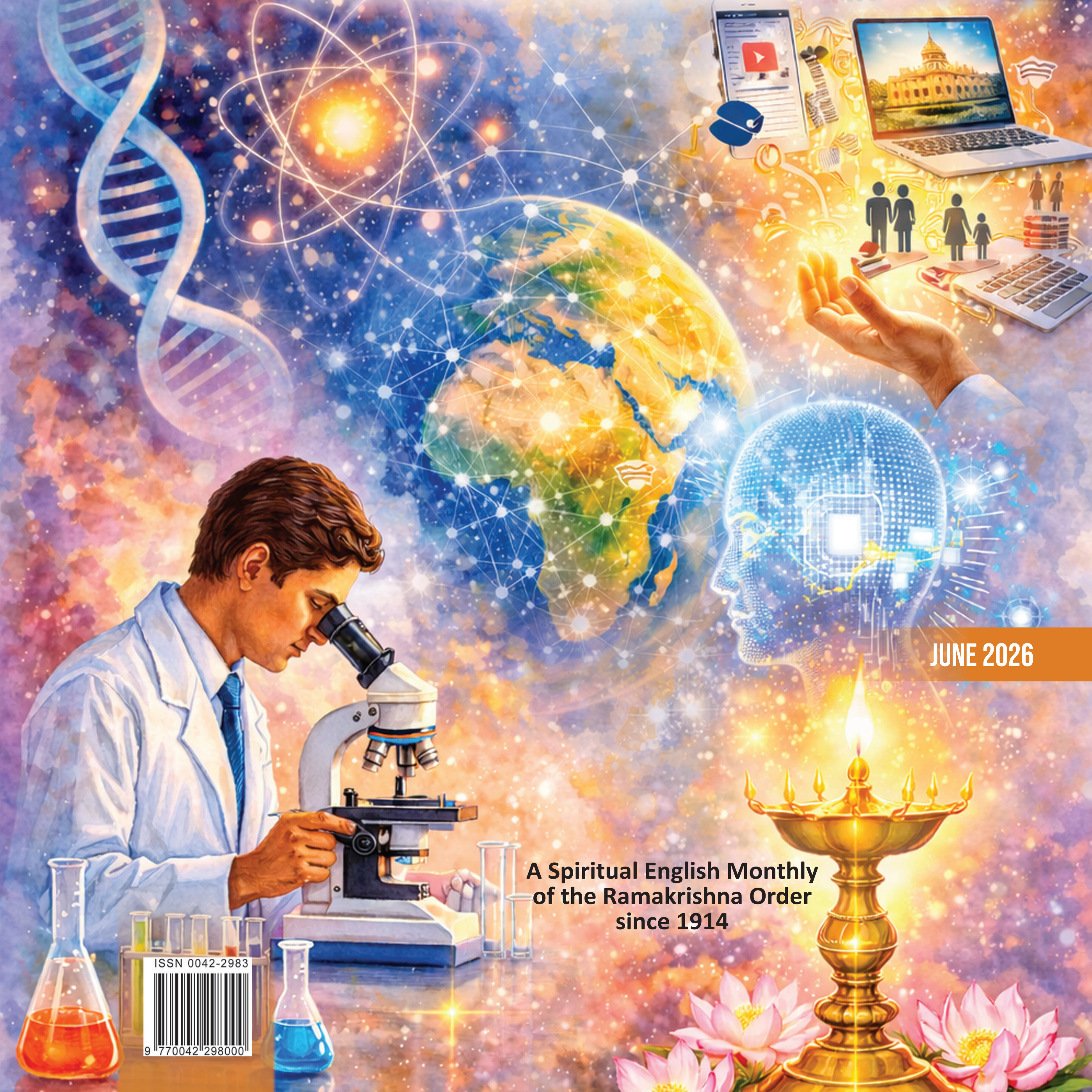
THE VEDANTA KESARI

Vol.113 ★ Issue: 6 ★ Monthly ★ June 2026 ★ Price: ₹ 20



JUNE 2026

A Spiritual English Monthly
of the Ramakrishna Order
since 1914

ISSN 0042-2983

Digi Sevā and Digi Dāna

Twin pillars of Service for a New Digital India

SWAMI PARAMASHIVANANDA

Wisdom before wealth

Swami Ranganathananda, the thirteenth President of the Ramakrishna Order, in an extempore speech at Mumbai, addressed to industrialists on 4 April 1979, said:

> If you want Shri (wealth), you must seek for and find something else behind it, and that something else is called Vāni, Sarasvati (Knowledge). Without Sarasvati, there can be no Shri, Lakshmi. … We are slowly learning the truth. These two values, knowledge on the one side and wealth and welfare on the other, always go together. All human wealth and welfare flow from tested and verified knowledge; therefore, so far as the human being is concerned, it is first knowledge, it is first science, Vidyā, then wealth and welfare, Shri. The truth of this is seen in the modern developments in the West. Western people first devoted themselves to Sarasvati, for example, scientific research. Through such research, they advanced people's knowledge of nature and the human being. Out of those primary *tapas* of knowledge-seeking, there came as a by-product that beautiful blessing of Shri, the blessing of wealth.[1]

Nation's greatest assets

Swami Ranganathananda further commented:

> In the field of human development, money comes second only in importance, and not the first. Money is static and dead unless invested in people. For that investment in people, the first requirement is the availability of dedicated youths in social groups, with the patriotic motivation to serve. Such groups must be created first. Money becomes useful only after that, not in the beginning. First, the right type of people, then money. Quite often, the government's projects begin with money and end with money; more thought is to be given to getting the right type of people, who can really translate money into effective human development. Educated, efficient, nationally dedicated men and women are the greatest assets of the state.[1]

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'Digital India' transformation

The 'Vidyā' (knowledge) that Swami Ranganathananda spoke of decades ago has sprouted into a new digital dawn for India. The DIGITAL INDIA is a flagship program launched by the Government of India on 1 July 2015, with the vision of transforming the country into a digitally empowered society and a knowledge based economy.[2] The program is at the forefront of driving technological innovation, encouraging research and development of digital solutions to address real-world challenges. Digital India has become a central driver of rural development by bridging the gap in urban-rural connectivity, governance, and economic opportunities. A couple of key focus areas of Digital India are 'Implementing digital services that are accessible to all, especially marginalised communities, differently abled individuals, and those in rural and remote areas. Supporting digital entrepreneurship involves providing resources like mentorship, technology access to innovators, empowering digital skills, promoting collaboration, thereby fostering creativity and boosting economic growth.'[3]

Young and rising India

Currently, India has the world's largest youth (aged 15 to 29) demographic of 371 million,[4] and it has solidified its position as a global digital powerhouse, driven by the synergistic impact of the Digital India initiative and a massive, tech-savvy youth population. This demographic dividend has embraced Artificial Intelligence not just as a tool, but as a catalyst for socio-economic transformation, propelling the nation towards a larger economy. From AI-driven precision farming in rural heartlands to sophisticated fintech solutions in urban hubs, the country is witnessing an unprecedented era of home-grown innovation. The government's focus on Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) has provided the necessary 'rails' for young entrepreneurs to build scalable, AI-first startups that solve local and global challenges. Moreover, wide-scale digital literacy programs have ensured that this technological surge is inclusive, bridging the urban-rural divide. As the world looks towards 2026, India stands as a model for how emerging technologies can empower a developing nation's workforce. This 'Rising India' manifests the 'can-do' spirit of a knowledge-first generation, leading global shifts in AI and Deep Tech alongside vital innovations in the areas of health care, education, and space exploration.

The dark shadow of digital adoption

While rapid digital adoption has unlocked vast opportunities, it has also cast a long shadow over the younger generation. Today's youth face a unique 'perfect storm': the crushing weight of hyper-competition in academics leaning towards high-paying technological jobs, AI-driven career instability, and the hollow connectivity of social media that often breeds more anxiety than community sharing. This internal distress is further heightened by external global instabilities like climate change, pandemics, and geopolitical unrest. The result is a generation that is technically 'linked' but emotionally isolated, navigating a rising tide of silent struggle and underserved emotional needs.

The spirit of Digi Sevā—Technology as a sacred service

Technology possesses a world-changing potential, yet its true power is only unlocked when guided by enlightened minds and selfless hearts. In an age where the digital revolution moves at a 'maddening speed,' there is an urgent need for course correction—one that replaces greed and ego with a vision to empower the marginalised. According to Swami Vivekananda, for such a transformation to happen, we need a generation of 'integrated personalities' who combine the 'Three Hs': a heart to feel, a head to think, and hands to work. He called for a selfless 'army' of sincere, courageous youth to traverse the land, preaching a gospel of social upliftment and equality.

Digi Sevā is a voluntary program born from this very idealism. It offers young professionals and students a unique opportunity to collaborate with the Ramakrishna Math and Mission, applying emerging technologies and research to solve real-world societal challenges in India. This program also offers 'Bring your own project', where interested individuals can bring in technical projects of their choice and, upon approval, utilise the Digi Sevā infrastructure for their work. Startups by students at the ideation phase can also be part of the Digi Sevā program. An option is also provided with a flexible hybrid model combining remote and on-site work.

Rooted in the mantra *ātmano mokṣārthaṃ jagaddhitāya ca* ('For one's salvation and the well-being of the world'), Digi Sevā provides a modern *tapovana* (forest-retreat) environment. In this tranquil space, one can cultivate reflection and meditation, balancing high-impact technical innovation yet protecting one's own emotional well-being. Professionally, Digi Sevā warriors gain hands-on experience and the autonomy to pursue innovative research. Personally, one discovers the profound joy and fulfilment that comes from Practical Vedanta—the philosophy of seeing selfless service as a path to life's ultimate purpose.[5]

Digi Dāna—Reimagining Indian philanthropy and the new role of NPOs

Swami Ranganathananda emphasises the need for wealth that serves as the essential support system for the growth of knowledge and the welfare of the people. He proclaims:

> All we need is to have a heart, and a searching eye, to be able to spot out where groups of dedicated young people are working, so that they can be helped and encouraged to do bigger and better things. Moneyed people in India should realise, more and more, that wise spending is what makes money into Shri; they should see, therefore, that no good work should languish for want of money; they should develop a spontaneous and constant mood and attitude of 'what I can do for you, how can I help you?' towards all good work.[1]

Digi Dāna is a complementary initiative to Digi Sevā, inviting both individuals and corporations to contribute financial support that fuels the mission of digital service and societal upliftment. Indian Philanthropy is also undergoing a transformation where CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility) donations towards NPOs (Non-Profit Organisations) are skewing from the traditional giving methodologies towards scientific research and knowledge-building infrastructure. Notable examples of this shift include investments in brain research and neuroscience aimed at understanding human cognition to tailor learning experiences to each individual, initiatives focused on leveraging Artificial Intelligence (AI) for education and skill development, and efforts directed toward addressing climate change through preventive measures and disaster relief preparedness.[6]

Digi Dāna aligns with this evolving landscape by channelling philanthropic support towards initiatives that truly matter. Non-Profit Organisations like Ramakrishna Math and Mission utilise this support from this new generation of philanthropists to modernise their outreach, embrace digital tools, and adopt the innovative mindset necessary to inspire and guide today's tech-savvy youth. In essence, while Digi Sevā offers the hands and hearts for service, Digi Dāna provides the vital resources that turn vision into reality, creating prosperity with a purpose.

Digi Sevā, rooted in Swami Vivekananda's three laws of innovation

Swami Vivekananda's reflective insights on pioneering new endeavours have been distilled into three laws of innovation, and Digi Sevā warriors imbibe these principles as guiding tenets throughout their journey of digital transformation. The first law is the 'Law of Duality in Innovation'. Swamiji observed that since the beginning of civilisation, a perpetual contest between opposing forces has shaped every domain of human activity.[7] In Physics, this manifests as the tension between centripetal and centrifugal force; in Politics, as the pull between liberalism and conservatism; in the world of labour, as the divide between white-collar and blue-collar work; and in Metaphysics, as the interplay of Yin and Yang. Human beings possess a remarkable ability to innovate in ways that can uplift society, yet these same innovations risk causing harm when ethical considerations are overlooked—social media, nuclear energy, and digital currency being notable examples. History shows us repeatedly that every significant innovation sparks a contest of perspectives, with one camp championing progress and the other voicing caution. The guiding principle, then, is to chart a balanced course and advance thoughtfully.

The second law of innovation is the 'Law of Progressive Acceptance'. Swami Vivekananda observed that every innovative, meaningful endeavour follows a predictable arc—it is first met with ridicule, then confronted with resistance, and only in time does it earn acceptance, eventually accompanied by respect. Those who envision possibilities ahead of their era will inevitably be misunderstood. Opposition and even persecution are unavoidable companions on the path of innovation, yet the visionary must remain unwavering in conviction and steadfast in integrity.[8]

The third law of innovation is 'Law of Three Ps—Purity, Patience, and Perseverance'. Swami Vivekananda affirmed that the triad of purity, patience, and perseverance holds the power to surmount every obstacle.[9] Transformative achievements are, by their very nature, gradual. Lasting innovation is not born of haste but of sustained effort guided by a clear conscience, calm resolve, and an unyielding spirit.

Award-winning Digi Sevā projects at Ramakrishna Math and Mission

Every Digi Sevā project is carefully conceived to bring together the best of two worlds—the precision and capability of modern scientific technologies and the depth and relevance of traditional Indian methodologies. This harmonious integration ensures that every initiative delivers meaningful and lasting benefits to society at large. Here is a sampler of the award-winning Digi Sevā projects executed by Ramakrishna Math and Mission:

WeMindYou app is an app developed to protect the emotional well-being of rural children, especially during Covid-19 lockdown. This app provides a digital workflow to identify the emotional well-being of young adolescents through facial analysis and a subjective questionnaire, empowers them with integrated body-mind training techniques like meditation/yoga, and finally verifies using neural correlates to ensure that there is an improvement in their emotional well-being. This award-winning app was implemented on a low-code platform, and it was submitted to an International Hackathon at Boston, where it won the first prize of US $35,000 among many entries from all over the world.[10]

Narendra Smart Toy is based on Swami Vivekananda's childhood persona, Narendra, which analyses the emotional well-being in children through facial and voice analysis and empowers them by providing mind fitness training through meditation game and inspirational stories. Meditation game and inspiring stories regulate the child's emotions, enabling them to have the mental strength to boldly face the difficulties of the world. Out of 17,000+ Idea submissions for the Toycathon, the Narendra Smart Toy, designed by our Ramakrishna Math Media Lab team, won in the 'Out-of-the-Box Creative and Logical Thinking' category (Tier 3), Govt of India Toycathon 2022.[11]

The majority of the digitisation of heritage artefacts associated with Swami Vivekananda and indoor/outdoor spaces related to Swami Vivekananda at Ramakrishna Math and Mission are in 2D format, and these are primarily done with photographic/video cameras. But if these could be scanned in 3D, it could provide a safeguard against potential loss or damage to these invaluable sites/materials due to natural disasters, vandalism, or other unforeseen events like geopolitical crises. The reason a 3D scan would be better is that the 2D photos or drawings cannot match the accuracy of a 3D scan. By creating detailed digital 3D replicas, we ensure the preservation and re-creation of the heritage artefacts and sites. RKMVERI (Vivekananda University), Belur Math has been selected by DST (Department of Science and Technology), Govt of India, among multiple applications for a funding of ₹83 Lakhs (USD $100,000) for 3D Scanning of heritage artefacts and spaces associated with Swami Vivekananda.[12]

Samsmriti Darshanam is another project that addresses India's unprecedented youth mental health crisis by enhancing mental well-being through a pioneering convergence of Traditional Indian Knowledge Systems (TIKS) with advanced technologies such as Generative AI and Mixed Reality (AR/VR Augmented Reality/Virtual Reality).[11] This project has been selected in the second round of funding by ANRF (Anusandhan National Research Foundation), Govt of India.[13]

Digi Sevā for students: Igniting young minds

Swami Ranganathananda spoke with great concern for modern youth:

> Most of the students take to education, only to pass examinations with a view to securing jobs, or now to go to America or Canada or the Arab countries for more paying jobs; very few, even after obtaining jobs within the nation, care for the nation or for the people. Our education must inspire our youth to develop their physical and mental energies fully and channel them into the service of the people in different fields. It is only in this more-than-individual dimension of energy-expression that the individual will find his or her own life fulfilled. This higher motivation has to be injected into the educational system, but today it is mostly costly and costlier education and not higher education![1]

Digi Sevā offers a practical pathway to realise this very vision. By introducing students to technology-driven Sevā at an early age, it plants the seeds of purpose and social consciousness long before the pressures of career and livelihood take hold. Young students engaged in Digi Sevā learn not just digital skills but also values of empathy, teamwork, and selfless contribution. They begin to see technology not as a mere tool for personal advancement but as a powerful instrument for uplifting communities. In this way, Digi Sevā transforms education into something that is truly higher—higher in intent, higher in impact, and higher in the fulfilment it brings to every young mind it touches. When we catch them young, we do not just shape better professionals—we nurture better human beings, thereby transforming them to enlightened citizens. Nachiketa Lab has been created at Sri Ramakrishna Math, Chennai, as part of Digi Sevā oriented for students.

Clarion call

The Digi Sevā program calls for a profound shift in how we perceive technological work, moving it from a mere career path to a transformative mission. In 1897, Swami Vivekananda thundered at the famous Victoria Hall in Chennai, 'Have you got the will to surmount mountain-high obstructions? If the whole world stands against you, sword in hand, would you still dare to do what you think is right? … If all your money goes, your name dies, your wealth vanishes, would you still stick to it? Would you still pursue it and go on steadily towards your goal?'[14] This uncompromising resolve is the bedrock upon which the Digi Sevā warrior must stand. In an era where digital trends shift rapidly, this brand of fearless, unshakeable willpower is essential to navigate the ridicule and opposition that inevitably meet those who think ahead of their time.

Digi Sevā warriors who embrace this mindset are capable of achieving extraordinary things. When individuals commit themselves wholeheartedly to a purpose greater than personal gain, a profound inner development—a Self-transformation—naturally takes place. The ultimate objective of Digi Sevā has always been this: that Self-transformation remains the primary goal—to awaken in every participant a spirit of selfless service, fearless innovation, and unwavering dedication to the welfare of society—while ideal digital innovation follows as a natural, inevitable side effect. When the inner transformation is real, the outer transformation becomes inevitable.

Note: A detailed FAQ and form are available on the Digi Sevā portal (https://rkmm.link/digiSevā) for those who wish to participate in this program. ॐ

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